

The Normanby Goldfield

Designing a Visual-First, Museum-Style Branching Digital Story

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Abstract

The aim of this project is to create an innovative Historical GIS (H-GIS) platform for recording, representing, manipulating, and transforming historical maps, archaeological surveys, images, and historical documentary sources to create 3D visualisations of the socio-archaeological history of the Normanby goldfield, spanning from the 1870s to present. Recent developments in digital geographic visualisation platforms have added new, cutting-edge tools historical archaeologists can employ to create spatio-temporal visualisations of historical landscapes.

Archaeological processes and events are best understood in a space and time setting. Maps represent the landscapes inside which pasts histories have taken place. Even though maps are static, they represent the spatial dimension of historical data, relationships, and features of interest at the time the map was made. Snapshots of temporal features can be acquired from a series of maps of various time periods. Yet, GIS, like most computational databases, does not easily support temporal data. This limitation is particularly problematic in archaeological investigations.

Recent developments in geographic visualisation commenced to address some of these issues. Developing processes to analyse spatial and temporal data in GIS, generates opportunities to visualise, navigate, and assess diverse sources of information within the larger archaeological community, thus enhancing possibilities and knowledge. In the field of social sciences and humanities, archaeologists are routinely employing geospatial technologies such as Geographic Information Systems (GIS) and photogrammetry applications for spatial modelling and analysis. In spite of this, the capacity of advanced visualisation methods using GIS have largely been neglected. The use of GIS for spatio-temporal visualisation methods can broaden the scope of archaeological research and knowledge.

I examine the design and implementation of a visual-first, non-linear (branching) digital narrative using a museum-style approach. Drawing on the Normanby Goldfield Storymap branching diagram (Fig.1), I evaluate tools such as ArcGIS StoryMaps (2026), Genially (2026), ThingLink (2026), and IIIF viewers (IIIF, 2026). I compare interaction models and propose two architectures: (Option A) using StoryMaps as the primary container with embedded Genially modules, and (Option B) using Genially as the primary interface with embedded StoryMaps. I conclude with recommended layouts, branching structures, and optimal use of sidecar components (in ArcGIS StoryMaps) for high-impact digital heritage storytelling.

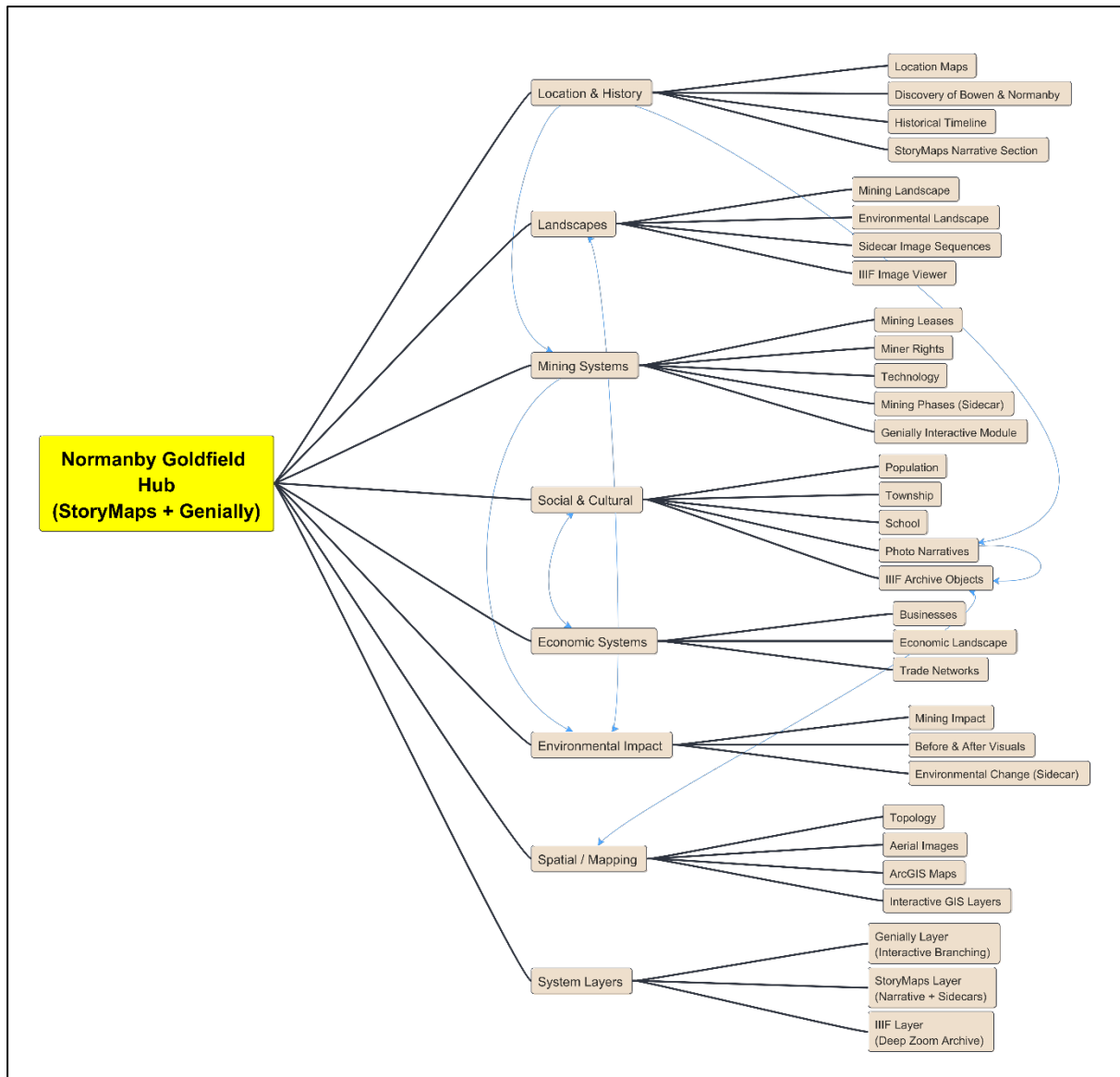


Figure 1: Normanby Goldfield Storymap branching diagram.

Visual-First Branching Narratives in Digital Storytelling

Introduction: a Critical Evaluation of Structure and Platform Capabilities

Branching narratives represent a fundamental shift in storytelling practice, departing from linear, author-directed sequences toward interactive, user-driven experiences. Rather than following a predetermined order, audiences navigate multiple thematic pathways, constructing their own interpretive journeys through a network of content. The Normanby goldfield storymap exemplifies this transition, offering a structure in which users can move freely between topics such as history, landscapes, mining systems, social life, economics, and environmental impacts.

I argue that visual-first, branching storytelling models, particularly those inspired by museum curation, offer a powerful framework for digital humanities projects by facilitating exploratory learning and multimodal engagement. However, their effectiveness depends on both conceptual design and platform useability. Through analysis of the Normanby storymap's branching structure (Fig.1) and a comparative evaluation of key platforms (ThingLink, Genially, and ArcGIS StoryMaps), this essay demonstrates that while branching narratives enhance user agency and interpretive flexibility, they also introduce challenges related to coherence, usability, and narrative depth.

Visual-First Storytelling and Narrative Logic

The Normanby storymap adopts a visual-first approach that prioritizes images, maps, and artifacts as primary narrative elements rather than supplementary illustrations. This model aligns closely with museum practices, where objects are curated and contextualized rather than embedded within strictly chronological narratives (Parry, 2013). In such environments, meaning is generated through connection, spatial organization, and user interaction.

This curatorial logic reflects broader trends in digital humanities, which emphasize multimodality and non-linear knowledge structures (Burdick, Drucker, Lunenfeld, Presner, & Schnapp, 2012). By foregrounding visual content, the storymap shifts interpretation from passive reception to active exploration. Users encounter discrete content nodes and construct relationships between them through navigation, effectively participating in the meaning-making process.

The pedagogical implications of this model are significant. Exploratory environments support constructivist learning, enabling users to develop understanding through interaction and discovery (Falk & Dierking, 2016). However, the same openness that enables engagement can also undermine narrative clarity. Without explicit guidance or structured progression, users may struggle to synthesise fragmented information into a coherent narrative. Thus, visual-first storytelling requires careful balance between freedom and orientation.

Conceptual Model: The Normanby Branching Structure

The Normanby storymap can be conceptualized as a node-based network organized around a central hub. The core node functions as a landing interface, presenting an overview and visual entry point into the narrative. From this hub, users access multiple primary branches, including Location & History, Landscapes, Mining Systems, Social & Cultural Life, Economic Systems, Environmental Impact, and Spatial/Mapping. Each of these branches

expands into secondary nodes, such as mining leases and technologies, population and township structures, or environmental degradation.

A defining feature of this system is its commitment to non-linear accessibility: any node can be accessed from any other. This is achieved through strong cross-linking, modular content blocks, and redundant navigation pathways. Such a structure reflects what Manovich (2001) identifies as the 'database logic' of digital media, where content exists as a collection of discrete elements rather than a singular narrative sequence.

While this modularity enhances flexibility and scalability, it also introduces cognitive challenges. Users must constantly orient themselves within a complex network of information, increasing the risk of disorientation or 'lostness' (Nielsen, 2012). Effective design therefore requires clear visual cues, consistent navigation systems, and meaningful thematic connections to ensure that users can construct coherent mental models of the content.

Comparative Platform Analysis

The realization of branching storytelling depends not only on conceptual structure but also on the affordances of digital platforms. Evaluating platforms in terms of visual interactivity, embedding capability, non-linear navigation, scalability, and media richness reveals distinct approaches to interactive storytelling.

ThingLink: Spatial Exploration and Implicit Branching

ThingLink is particularly effective for spatial and exploratory storytelling. By placing interactive hotspots on images, videos, or 360-degree environments, it creates a node-based system in which each interaction reveals new content. This produces an implicit form of branching, where users navigate through a visual environment rather than making explicit narrative choices.

From a storytelling perspective, ThingLink excels in creating immersive experiences such as virtual tours or exhibition-style interfaces. Its design aligns with experiential learning models, emphasizing discovery and engagement over structured narrative progression (Falk & Dierking, 2016).

However, its reliance on spatial navigation limits its capacity for complex narrative logic. It lacks mechanisms for conditional branching or decision-based outcomes, meaning that user choices do not significantly alter narrative trajectories. As a result, ThingLink is best understood as a tool for exploratory environments rather than for fully developed branching narratives.

Genially: Explicit Branching and Narrative Control

Genially represents the most comprehensive platform for structured branching storytelling. It integrates interactive design, animation, and user interface elements to create explicit decision pathways. Users navigate through clickable buttons, hidden links, and layered interactions, enabling the construction of 'choose-your-own-adventure' narratives and gamified experiences.

This capacity for structured branching aligns with Ryan's (2015) concept of interactive narrative, where user choices influence the progression and outcome of the story. Genially allows for multiple narrative pathways, alternative endings, and conditional content presentation, thereby enhancing user agency and engagement.

In addition, its support for multimedia elements, video, audio, animation, and interactive infographics, enables richly layered storytelling. This multimodality enhances accessibility and engagement across diverse audiences.

Nevertheless, Genially's flexibility introduces complexity. Large projects may become difficult to manage, particularly when multiple branching pathways intersect. Furthermore, its logic is primarily visual and simulated rather than algorithmic, limiting the sophistication of narrative conditions compared to programming-based platforms such as Twine. Despite these limitations, Genially provides the most balanced environment for combining visual richness with structured narrative branching.

ArcGIS StoryMaps: Linear Narratives with Exploratory Features

ArcGIS StoryMaps offers a different model, combining linear storytelling with interactive geographic visualization. Its primary strength lies in integrating narrative text with spatial data, allowing users to explore maps, toggle layers, and analyse geographic relationships.

This platform is particularly suited to research-driven storytelling, where spatial context is central. Its scalability allows for the presentation of large datasets and complex visualizations, making it valuable for academic and institutional projects.

However, ArcGIS StoryMaps provides limited support for branching narratives. Its structure is fundamentally linear, with optional navigation between sections rather than true non-linear pathways. While users can explore maps interactively, their overall narrative trajectory remains largely fixed.

As a result, ArcGIS StoryMaps is best understood as a hybrid platform that supports guided storytelling with elements of exploration. It prioritizes clarity and coherence over narrative flexibility, making it less suitable for projects requiring multiple narrative paths or user-driven outcomes.

Key Differences and Theoretical Implications

The comparison between ThingLink, Genially, and ArcGIS StoryMaps highlights three distinct modes of interactive storytelling:

- Spatial exploration (ThingLink): Interaction occurs through movement within a visual environment.
- User Interface (UI) driven branching (Genially): Interaction is structured through explicit user choices and narrative pathways.
- Data-centered exploration (ArcGIS StoryMaps): Interaction focuses on interpreting embedded spatial data within a guided narrative.

These modes reflect broader tensions in digital storytelling between openness and control, exploration and coherence. As Ryan (2015) argues, interactive narratives must balance user agency with authorial intent to maintain both engagement and intelligibility. Excessive freedom can lead to fragmentation, while overly rigid structures can limit engagement.

In the case of the Normanby storymap, this suggests that platform selection is not merely a technical decision but a conceptual one. A platform like ThingLink reinforces the project's museum-style, exploratory ethos, while Genially enables more structured interpretive pathways. ArcGIS StoryMaps enhances spatial analysis but constrains narrative branching.

Discussion

Visual-first branching narratives offer a compelling framework for digital storytelling, particularly within the humanities. By prioritizing interactivity, multimodality, and user agency, they enable audiences to engage with content in more dynamic and personalized ways. The Normanby goldfield storymap demonstrates how such models can integrate diverse thematic content into a cohesive, non-linear structure grounded in curatorial principles.

However, these benefits come with challenges. Non-linear systems can fragment narratives, increase cognitive load, and complicate design processes. The success of branching storytelling depends on carefully balancing flexibility with clarity and selecting platforms that align with conceptual goals.

Among the platforms evaluated, Genially emerges as the most versatile solution for branching narratives, offering strong interactivity, media richness, and narrative control. ThingLink excels in immersive, exploratory contexts, while ArcGIS StoryMaps remains best suited for structured, data-driven storytelling.

Ultimately, the effectiveness of visual-first branching narratives lies not simply in their ability to provide choice, but in their capacity to support meaningful interpretation. When thoughtfully designed, they transform storytelling from a fixed sequence into an interactive system of knowledge, enabling users to actively construct understanding through exploration.

Evaluating a Visual-First, Multi-Platform Digital Heritage Project

An ArcGIS StoryMaps, Genially, and a IIIF Viewer Design

The Normanby Goldfield project represents an ambitious attempt to reimagine historical storytelling through a visual-first, museum-inspired digital environment. By combining ArcGIS StoryMaps, Genially, and IIIF Viewer, the project creates a layered experience that blends narrative, interactivity, and archival depth. This approach reflects broader developments in digital humanities, where spatial technologies and multimedia interfaces are increasingly used to communicate complex historical knowledge. While the project offers significant advantages in accessibility, engagement, and interpretive potential, it also raises critical challenges related to usability, coherence, and scholarly depth. A balanced evaluation reveals that its success ultimately depends on how effectively it mediates between immersion and clarity, and between storytelling and critical analysis.

Visual-First Storytelling and the Museum Framework

One of the most compelling aspects of the project is its use of a museum model to structure digital experience. Rather than presenting information as a linear essay or static webpage, the design organizes content into thematic 'rooms', Discovery, History. Mining, Landscapes, Social Life, and Economy. This structure is immediately intuitive, as it reflects the spatial logic of physical exhibitions. Users are guided through a curated journey, progressing from entry orientation to deeper thematic exploration. This not only enhances usability but also reinforces narrative logic, as each section builds upon the previous one to construct a broader historical understanding.

The visual-first approach further strengthens this design. Instead of prioritising dense textual explanation, the project foregrounds maps, images, and interactive elements. For a subject like the Normanby Goldfield, where geography, movement, and environmental change are central, this emphasis is particularly appropriate. Maps allow users to see where mining occurred, how settlement adjusted, and how landscapes were transformed. Similarly, archival images provide a tangible connection to the past, grounding abstract historical processes in material evidence. By privileging visual information, the project aligns with contemporary expectations for digital content, which increasingly favour multimodal engagement over purely textual formats.

Nevertheless, this advantage also brings a drawback. Depending on visual storytelling can lead to an oversimplification of intricate historical events. Although images can effectively

show changes over time and space, they might have difficulty expressing subtle details, causes, or scholarly discussions. Without enough written explanation, viewers might develop only a shallow grasp of the topic. Therefore, while the museum analogy boosts interest, it must be carefully balanced with thoughtful analysis to prevent it from being merely an experience without depth.

The Power and Complexity of Multi-Platform Integration

A defining feature of the project is its integration of three distinct platforms: StoryMaps, Genially, and a IIIF Viewer. Each plays a specific role within the overall design. StoryMaps serves as the narrative backbone, guiding users through the exhibition in a structured sequence. Genially introduces interactivity, allowing users to engage with timelines, diagrams, and clickable environments. A IIIF Viewer provides access to high-resolution archival materials, enabling close examination of primary sources. Together, these tools create a layered interpretive framework, where users can choose different levels of engagement depending on their interests and expertise.

This multi-platform strategy is particularly effective in accommodating diverse audiences. Casual users may follow the StoryMaps narrative without engaging deeply with external tools, while more advanced users can explore Genially interactions or delve into a IIIF Viewer's archival collections. In this sense, the project demonstrates strong pedagogical potential, supporting different learning styles and levels of inquiry.

Despite these advantages, the use of multiple platforms also introduces significant usability challenges. Each platform has its own interface, interaction style, and navigation logic. Transitions between them can feel abrupt, disrupting the flow of the user experience. For instance, moving from a StoryMaps narrative to a Genially interactive panel may require a shift in attention and orientation, while Mirador's more technical interface may be unfamiliar to general audiences. Without careful design, these transitions risk fragmenting the narrative and creating confusion.

Moreover, reliance on external platforms raises concerns about technical stability and longevity. Embedded content may fail to load properly, particularly in environments with limited internet connectivity. Updates to platform interfaces or policies could also affect long-term accessibility. These issues highlight a broader challenge in digital humanities projects: the tension between innovation and sustainability.

Engagement, Interactivity, and Cognitive Load

Interactivity is central to the project's design. Features such as clickable maps, animated timelines, and interactive townscapes encourage users to actively explore the

material rather than passively consume information. This aligns with constructivist learning theories, which emphasize the importance of active engagement in knowledge acquisition. By allowing users to control their own exploration, the project fosters a sense of discovery that mirrors the historical experiences it represents.

Genially, in particular, plays a key role in this regard. Its interactive features enable the creation of dynamic visualizations, such as timeline sliders and hotspot-based maps. These tools transform static information into engaging experiences, making it easier for users to understand processes like technological change or economic development.

However, the emphasis on interactivity also raises the risk of cognitive overload. When users are presented with too many clickable elements, animations, and layers of information, the experience can become overwhelming. Instead of enhancing understanding, excessive interactivity may distract from the core narrative. This is especially problematic in educational contexts, where clarity and focus are essential.

To mitigate this issue, the project must employ selective interactivity, ensuring that each interactive element serves a clear interpretive purpose. Not every piece of information needs to be interactive; in many cases, a well-designed map or concise text block may be more effective. The challenge lies in identifying which aspects of the story benefit most from interaction and which are better conveyed through simpler means.

Archival Depth and the Role of a IIIF Viewer

The inclusion of Mirador as an archival viewer adds significant depth to the project. Unlike StoryMaps and Genially, which prioritize presentation and engagement, a IIIF Viewer allows for detailed examination of primary sources. Users can zoom into maps, compare images, and explore documents in high resolution. This transforms the project from a purely interpretive narrative into a research-oriented resource.

This feature is particularly valuable for supporting critical inquiry. By providing access to original materials, the project encourages users to engage with evidence directly, rather than relying solely on curated interpretations. This aligns with best practices in digital humanities, which emphasize transparency and the importance of primary sources.

Nevertheless, the use of a IIIF Viewer also introduces a steep learning curve. Its interface is less intuitive than those of ArcGIS StoryMaps or Genially, and users unfamiliar with digital archives may find it difficult to navigate. As a result, its potential may remain underutilized unless accompanied by clear guidance or tutorials. Additionally, the integration of a IIIF Viewer must be carefully managed to ensure that it complements, rather than disrupts, the overall narrative flow.

Narrative, Interpretation, and Academic Rigour

While the project excels in creating an engaging and visually rich experience, it also raises questions about academic rigour and interpretive depth. Digital storytelling often prioritizes accessibility and engagement, which can sometimes come at the expense of critical analysis. In this project, the narrative structure provides a coherent overview of the Normanby Goldfield, but it may not fully address complex issues such as economic inequality, environmental impact, or Indigenous perspectives.

This highlights a broader tension within digital humanities: the need to balance storytelling with scholarly analysis. A successful project must do more than present information; it must also interpret it, situating it within broader historical and theoretical contexts. This may require the inclusion of more detailed textual analysis, citations, or links to further reading.

At the same time, the project's format offers opportunities for innovative forms of interpretation. For example, interactive maps could be used to visualise patterns of inequality or environmental change, while archival materials could support critical discussions of historical narratives. By leveraging its technological capabilities, the project has the potential to move beyond descriptive storytelling toward more analytical engagement.

Discussion

The Normanby Goldfield project represents a thoughtful and innovative approach to digital heritage storytelling, combining visual design, interactivity, and archival research within a cohesive framework. Its strengths lie in its museum-style structure, visual-first approach, and multi-platform integration, all of which contribute to an engaging and accessible user experience. At the same time, these features introduce challenges related to usability, cognitive load, and narrative coherence. The project also highlights the ongoing tension between engagement and academic rigour in digital humanities.

Ultimately, the success of the project depends on achieving a careful balance. Visuals must support, rather than replace, critical analysis; interactivity must enhance, rather than overwhelm, understanding; and multiple platforms must be integrated in a way that feels seamless rather than fragmented. When these elements are effectively aligned, the project has the potential to serve as a powerful model for future digital storytelling initiatives—demonstrating how history can be made both accessible and meaningful in the digital age.

Selecting a Base Platform for Digital Storytelling

The choice of a base platform for digital storytelling is not merely a technical decision but a fundamentally epistemological one, shaping how narratives are structured, how audiences interact with content, and how knowledge is presented and interpreted. In the context of combining ArcGIS StoryMaps and Genially, two distinct configurations emerge: StoryMaps as the base platform with Genially embedded (Option A), and Genially as the base platform with StoryMaps embedded (Option B). Each approach embodies different assumptions about narrative structure, interactivity, and audience engagement. In this section, I critically evaluate these options, arguing that the optimal choice depends on the project's epistemic priorities, whether it favours structured, research-led storytelling or exploratory, participatory engagement.

Narrative Architecture and the Framework of Knowledge

At its core, StoryMaps is designed around linear or semi-linear narrative progression, integrating text, multimedia, and spatial data within a coherent geographic framework. This aligns with traditional academic storytelling conventions, where arguments unfold sequentially and build cumulatively (Esri, 2026). Option A (StoryMaps as base) therefore reproduces a familiar rhetorical structure: introduction, contextualisation, analysis, and conclusion. Embedded Genially elements function as interactive interruptions that enrich rather than redefine the narrative trajectory.

In contrast, Genially emphasizes non-linear navigation and interactive discovery. Its design allows users to navigate freely among different pieces of information, forming a web-like rather than a hierarchical organization of knowledge (Genially, 2026). Therefore, Option B embodies a constructivist approach to knowledge, where understanding is created collaboratively through user engagement instead of being delivered through a fixed storyline (Jenkins, 2006). The integrated StoryMaps feature serves as an additional in-depth exploration rather than the main narrative framework.

The distinction between these approaches is not trivial. Linear narratives emphasise authorial control and interpretive clarity, while non-linear systems privilege user agency and multiplicity of perspectives. As Ryan (2015) argues, digital narratives oscillate between these poles, and platform choice determines where a project sits on this spectrum.

Strengths of Option A: StoryMaps as Narrative Backbone

Option A offers several key advantages that make it particularly suited to research-driven and institutional contexts. First, its strong geographic and thematic structuring enables

complex spatial narratives to be communicated effectively. StoryMaps' integration of maps, timelines, and multimedia supports what Caquard and Cartwright (2014) describe as narrative cartography, the use of spatial frameworks to organise and interpret stories. This is especially valuable for projects involving place-based histories, environmental change, or heritage interpretation.

Second, the platform's stability and readability enhance its suitability for long-form content. Academic audiences often require sustained engagement with detailed arguments, and StoryMaps supports this through features such as sidecar scrolling, which pairs visual and textual elements in an organised flow. This aligns with established practices of digital humanities scholarship, where clarity and accessibility are paramount (Berry, 2012).

Third, Option A is well suited to public-facing institutional outputs. Museums, universities, and heritage organisations often prioritise credibility, consistency, and ease of navigation. A StoryMaps-based architecture ensures that users can follow a guided pathway through the material, minimising intellectual overload while maintaining interpretive authority.

However, these strengths come with limitations. The linearity of StoryMaps constrains branching interaction, reducing opportunities for users to explore alternative pathways or personalise their experience. While embedded Genially components can introduce interactivity, they remain subordinate to the overarching narrative structure. As a result, Option A may not fully exploit the participatory potential of digital media.

Strengths of Option B: Genially as Interactive Framework

Option B reverses these priorities, foregrounding interactivity and user agency. Genially's visual-first interface and branching logic create an experience akin to a digital exhibition, where users navigate through a network of interconnected elements. This museum exhibit feel is particularly effective for public engagement and educational contexts, where exploration and discovery are key pedagogical strategies (Falk & Dierking, 2016).

The capacity for non-linear navigation allows for multiple entry points and pathways, accommodating diverse user interests and learning styles. This aligns with contemporary approaches to digital pedagogy, which emphasise active learning and user-driven exploration (Laurillard, 2012). In this sense, Option B represents a shift from storytelling to story-experience design, where the narrative emerges through interaction rather than being pre-scripted.

Moreover, Genially's strong visual emphasis enhances engagement, particularly for audiences less accustomed to textual analysis. Interactive elements such as hotspots, animations, and branching scenarios can make complex content more accessible and

engaging. This is especially valuable for outreach initiatives or projects targeting younger or non-specialist audiences.

Nevertheless, Option B also presents challenges. Its emphasis on interactivity can make it difficult to sustain long-form argumentation. Without a clear narrative spine, users may struggle to piece together a coherent understanding of the material. This fragmentation risks undermining the depth and rigour expected in academic or research-driven projects (Manovich, 2013).

Additionally, the integration of spatial narratives is less seamless than in StoryMaps. While maps can be embedded, they do not function as the organising principle of the experience. For projects where geography is central, this represents a significant limitation.

Comparative Analysis: Narrative Control vs User Agency

The choice between Option A and Option B ultimately hinges on a fundamental tension between narrative control and user agency. Option A prioritises the former, offering a structured, authoritative narrative that guides users through a carefully curated sequence. Option B prioritises the latter, enabling users to construct their own pathways and interpretations.

This tension reflects broader debates in digital storytelling and media theory. Jenkins (2006) highlights the rise of participatory culture, where audiences are no longer passive consumers but active contributors. At the same time, scholars such as Ryan (2015) caution that excessive interactivity can dilute narrative coherence, leading to fragmented or superficial engagement.

From this perspective, neither option is inherently superior; rather, each serves different communicative goals. Option A is better suited to projects where clarity, coherence, and scholarly rigour are paramount. Option B is more effective for projects that prioritise engagement, exploration, and experiential learning.

Toward a Hybrid Strategy?

While this analysis has presented Option A and Option B as distinct configurations, it is worth considering the potential for hybrid approaches that combine their strengths. For example, a StoryMaps based structure could incorporate multiple Genially modules that offer branching exploration within defined sections. Conversely, a Genially interface could include guided pathways that approximate linear storytelling for users who prefer structured navigation.

Such hybrid strategies reflect the increasing convergence of narrative and interactive design in digital media. As Murray (2017) argues, the future of digital storytelling lies in

balancing agency and authorship, creating experiences that are both engaging and meaningful.

Discussion

The decision between StoryMaps and Genially as a base platform is not simply a matter of technical preference but a strategic choice that shapes the nature of the narrative itself. Option A (StoryMaps + Genially) offers a structured, research-led approach that excels in academic and institutional contexts, particularly where spatial narratives are central. Option B (Genially + StoryMaps) provides a more exploratory, interactive framework that is well suited to public engagement and educational applications.

Ultimately, the choice depends on the goals of the project: whether it seeks to guide users through a coherent argument or invite them to explore a network of possibilities. Recognising this distinction allows designers to align platform architecture with narrative intent, ensuring that form and content work together to create a compelling and effective digital experience.

Conclusion

This project demonstrates that visual-first, branching narratives provide a powerful and flexible framework for representing complex historical and archaeological knowledge in the digital age. By integrating GIS-based spatial analysis with interactive storytelling tools, the Normanby Goldfield H-GIS platform moves beyond static representation toward a dynamic, user-driven model of interpretation. It highlights how historical landscapes can be reassembled through layered visualisations, enabling users to explore relationships between place, time, and human activity in ways that traditional linear narratives cannot fully capture.

The evaluation of platforms and architectures shows that effective digital storytelling depends on aligning conceptual design with technological affordances. ArcGIS StoryMaps offers coherence, structure, and strong spatial grounding; Genially enables branching interactivity and user agency; and IIIF viewers contribute archival depth and research transparency. Whether implemented through a linear backbone (Option A) or an exploratory interface (Option B), the success of the system ultimately lies in balancing narrative clarity with interactive freedom.

At a broader level, the project underscores a key challenge in digital humanities: negotiating the tension between engagement and scholarly rigour. Visual and interactive approaches can make complex histories accessible and compelling, but they must be carefully designed to support critical analysis rather than replace it. Similarly, multi-platform integration

expands interpretive possibilities but requires thoughtful coordination to maintain usability and coherence.

Ultimately, the Normanby Goldfield project illustrates how digital heritage platforms can transform storytelling into an interactive process of knowledge construction. When successfully balanced, visualisation, interactivity, and spatial analysis do not simply present history—they enable users to actively investigate and interpret it. In doing so, this work contributes a valuable model for future H-GIS and digital storytelling initiatives, demonstrating how technology can deepen both engagement and understanding in the study of the past.

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